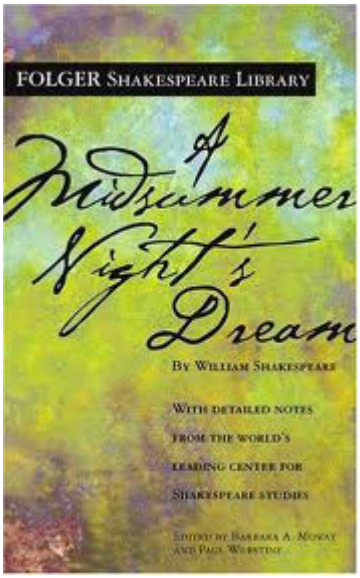
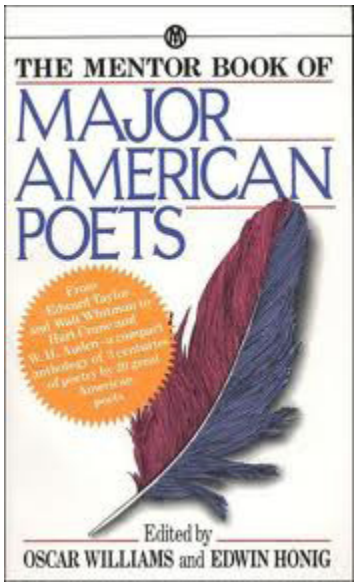
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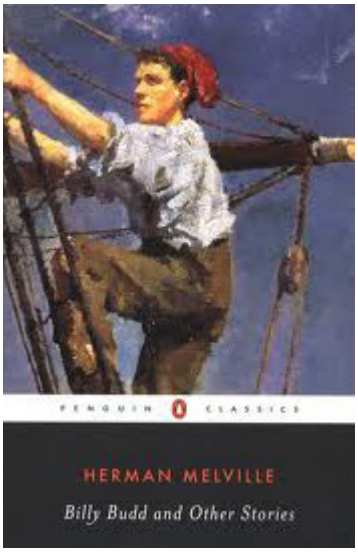
Making a World of Difference

Literary Criticism

State • 2012







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University Interscholastic League
Literary Criticism Contest • State • 2012

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History **30 items (1 point each)**

1. The term first used as a substitute for "popular antiquities" but now used to categorize the comparison and identification of the surviving evidence of archaic beliefs, customs, and traditions in modern ages is

   A) folk ballad.
   B) folk etymology.
   C) folklore.
   D) folk song.
   E) folktale.

2. A long, rambling, somewhat vague and unlikely story, a meandering tall tale is called a(n)

   A) anecdote.
   B) blood and thunder story.
   C) broadside ballad.
   D) cock-and-bull story.
   E) Märchen.

3. An extended and vigorous verbal exchange, often found in Old English poetry, as well as Greek, Arabic, Celtic, Italian, and Provençal poetry is (the)

   A) bombast.
   B) flyting.
   C) gasconade.
   D) rodomontade.
   E) stichomythia.

4. The metric foot used occasionally by Gerard Manley Hopkins, but otherwise uncommon in English versification, that consists of one stressed syllable and three unstressed syllables—in **no** specific order—is the

   A) anapestic.
   B) dactylic.
   C) paeon.
   D) spondaic.
   E) trochaic.

5. The author of *Sportswriter* and of its sequel *Independence Day*, for which he received the 1996 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction, is

   A) John Cheever.
   B) Richard Ford.
   C) Edward P. Jones.
   D) Philip Roth.
   E) Peter Taylor.

6. The term applied to a collection of poems or romances centering on one outstanding event or character, including the medieval treatment of biblical themes in dramatic form, is

   A) allegory.
   B) cycle.
   C) *fabliaux*.
   D) mummery.
   E) pageant.

7. The quality in art and literature that stimulates pity, tenderness, or sorrow is

   A) bathos.
   B) ethos.
   C) logos.
   D) mythos.
   E) pathos.

8. **Not** a type of literature, or genre, that a local school board might object to being taught in one of its classrooms, is

   A) bestiary.
   B) coprology.
   C) erotica.
   D) libertine play.
   E) pornography.

9. The Egyptian writer and recipient of the 1988 Nobel Prize for Literature, whose death interrupted his effort to write thirty books (over half of those completed having been made into films) covering the history of Egypt, is

   A) Elfriede Jelinek.
   B) Naguib Mahfouz.
   C) V. S. Naipaul.
   D) Orphan Pamuk.
   E) Rabindranath Tagore.

10. The worship of material and mechanical prosperity and the disregard of culture, beauty, and spirit defines

    A) asteism.
    B) Dadaism.
    C) medievalism.
    D) Philistinism.
    E) primitivism.

11. The eponymic term for an expression, often involving a pun, that gives a literal sense to a figurative statement, such as "'Simply remarkable,' said the teacher when asked her opinion about the new dry-erase board," is

A) Gongorism.
B) malapropism.
C) Marinism.
D) Spoonerism.
E) Wellerism.

12. The term used by Lionel Trilling for a kind of novel that deals with the experiences of a naïve, inexperienced visitor from a rural or agricultural region to a large city or metropolis is

A) adventure story.
B) *Bildungsroman*.
C) Hollywood novel.
D) lyrical novel.
E) Young Man from the Provinces.

13. The period in English literary history that reflects the rise of nineteenth-century British imperialism and a growth in British cosmopolitanism, as well as the emergence of the scientific revolution, is the

A) Modernist Period.
B) Neoclassical Period.
C) Post-Modernist Period.
D) Realistic Period.
E) Romantic Period.

14. The author of *The Heart Is a Lonely Hunter*, *The Ballad of the Sad Café*, and *The Member of the Wedding* is

A) Carson McCullers.
B) Joyce Carol Oates.
C) Flannery O'Connor.
D) Katherine Anne Porter.
E) Alice Walker.

15. Samuel Taylor Coleridge's phrase that addresses an audience's willingness to withhold questions about truth, accuracy, or probability in a work is

A) alienation effect.
B) jumping the shark.
C) moment of final suspense.
D) objective correlative.
E) suspension of disbelief.

16. The eighteenth-century Irish satirist whose works, including *A Tale of a Tub*, *Gulliver's Travels*, and "A Modest Proposal," were originally published either anonymously or pseudonymously is

A) William Congreve.
B) John Dryden.
C) William Hogarth.
D) Alexander Pope.
E) Jonathan Swift.

17. The type, often literary, that as a model of the mysteriously brooding, bitter, vaguely northern loner, sexually polymorphous, reckless, doomed, and always dangerous, is known as

A) Acmeism.
B) Byronism.
C) Gongorism.
D) Marinism.
E) Orphism.

18. A composition, usually verse, arranged in such a way that it spells a word, phrases or sentences when certain letters are selected according to an orderly sequence is a(n)

A) acrostic.
B) *carmen figuratum*.
C) clerihew.
D) riddle.
E) square poem.

19. The playwright whose *Our Town* and *The Skin of Our Teeth* earned him the Pulitzer Prizes for Drama in both 1938 and 1943 is

A) David Auburn.
B) Horton Foote.
C) Sidney Kingsley.
D) John Patrick.
E) Thornton Wilder

20. **Not** among the well-known tetralogies of either the British or the modern American literary canons is

A) Lawrence Durrell's *Alexandria Quartet*.
B) Philip Roth's Zuckerman novels.
C) J. K. Rowling's Harry Potter series.
D) Shakespeare's Richard and Henry plays.
E) John Updike's Rabbit Angstrom novels.

21. The author of the eight-novel Albany Cycle whose *Ironweed* earned him the 1984 Pulitzer Prize for Fiction is

A) Saul Bellow.
B) William Kennedy.
C) Cormac McCarthy.
D) Philip Roth.
E) John Updike.

22. Poems designed to complement each other are known as

A) autotelic poems.
B) companion poems.
C) metaphysical poems.
D) occasional poems.
E) topographical poems.

23. Generally, a word or name that resembles another and is used in its place for the sake of euphemism, insult, avoidance of libel, or some other purpose, such as "Colonel C. E. Florence" for Colonel T. E. Lawrence and "Alfred Venison" for Alfred Tennyson, is a(n)

A) anagram.
B) oxymoron.
C) palindrome.
D) paragram.
E) Spoonerism.

24. **Not** contributing—by writing a lengthy treatment of one of its main characters—to the lasting popularity of the Arthurian Legend is

A) Geoffrey Chaucer.
B) Geoffrey of Monmouth.
C) Thomas Malory.
D) Alfred, Lord Tennyson.
E) Mark Twain.

25. The type of writing in which words containing certain letters of the alphabet are not used, the greater challenge being the avoidance of words containing a specific vowel, is called a(n)

A) arabesque.
B) diastich.
C) koine.
D) lipogram.
E) logotype.

26. An innocent, artless, often virginal young girl, common in many literary forms as well as television is known as a(n)

A) *femme fatale*.
B) ingénue.
C) *la femme inspiratrice*.
D) miles gloriosus.
E) naïve narrator.

27. An ancient Scandinavian poet, especially of the Viking period, is called a

A) bard.
B) filidh.
C) gleeman.
D) scop.
E) skald.

28. The period in English literary history narrowly framed by the reign of Queen Anne and more broadly framed by the dates of Alexander Pope (1688-1744), in which the writers were self-consciously aware of the parallels of their writing to Latin literature, is called the

A) Augustan Age.
B) Caroline Age.
C) Edwardian Age.
D) Jacobean Age.
E) Late Victorian Age.

29. The 1990 Poet Laureate of the United States and recipient of the 1999 Pulitzer Prize for Poetry for his collection *Blizzard of One* is

A) Ted Kooser.
B) James Merrill.
C) Mark Strand.
D) Henry Taylor.
E) Charles Wright.

30. The study or philosophy of the beautiful in nature and art, which in literature concentrates on the sense of the beautiful rather than the moral, social, or practical considerations, is

A) aesthetics.
B) essentialism.
C) expressionism.
D) formalism.
E) Hebraism.

Part 2: The UIL Reading List **20 items (2 points each)**

Items 31-37 are associated with William Shakespeare's *A Midsummer Night's Dream*.
Items 38-44 are associated with Herman Melville's *Billy Budd, Sailor, An Inside Narrative*.
Items 45-50 are associated with Marianne Moore's poetry (selected).

31. In Shakespeare's *Midsummer Night's Dream*, Demetrius' response to Theseus' comment "I wonder if the lion be to speak"**:** "No wonder, my lord, One lion may when many asses do" suggests that the audience
    A) arrived late to the play.
    B) cannot understand animals like Dr. Dolittle.
    C) does not appreciate the Mechanicals' efforts.
    D) has no idea how theater works.
    E) is having difficulty understanding lines and accents.

32. Bottom's request of Titania that she "let none of your people stir me; I have an exposition of sleep come upon me" features a
    A) Gongorism.
    B) malapropism.
    C) Marinism.
    D) Spoonerism.
    E) Wellerism.

33. Titania's falling in love with a transformed Bottom points to the transformative power of
    A) drama.
    B) illusion.
    C) forests.
    D) love.
    E) lust.

34. Titania, to Oberon, observes, "The spring, the summer, / The childing autumn, angry winter, change / Their wonted liveries, and the mazèd world / By their increase knows not which"; *liveries* refers to
    A) appearances.
    B) changelings.
    C) corn fields.
    D) the other fairies.
    E) the seasons.

35. The overall thematic movement in Shakespeare's *Midsummer Night's Dream*, apparent in all four of the plot lines, is
    A) from annoyance to vexation.
    B) from conflict to harmony.
    C) from love to hate.
    D) from magic to mystery.
    E) from the woods to the underworld.

36. In preparation for the production of the play, Quince declares, "Well, we will have such a prologue, and it shall be written in eight and six," which suggests the standard meter for a
    A) ballad stanza.
    B) fourteener.
    C) melodrama.
    D) Shakespearean sonnet.
    E) tragicomedy.

37. The conversation between Hermia and Helena, "The more I hate, the more he follows me"**;** "The more I love, the more he hateth me" features
    A) anaphora.
    B) chiasmus.
    C) ellipsis.
    D) parallelism.
    E) parataxis.

---

38. The narrator of *Billy Budd* comments early on that Budd's story "is no romance," hinting that the story is (a)
    A) comedy.
    B) homoerotic.
    C) melodrama.
    D) recantation.
    E) tragedy.

39. Captain Vere's predisposition to rely on "remote allusions," even though they might be "alien to men whose reading was mainly confined" to contemporary writing, reminds the reader of
    A) the Dansker.
    B) Nathaniel Hawthorne.
    C) Herman Melville.
    D) the narrator himself.
    E) Admiral Nelson.

40. In asking, "Who in the rainbow can draw a line where the violet tint ends and the orange tint begins?" the narrator is asking the reader to consider
    A) Claggart's sociopathy.
    B) the colours of the Union Jack.
    C) the meteorological conditions after the storm.
    D) the meteorological conditions during the hanging.
    E) Vere's sanity.

41. In reflecting upon both "the moral and the practical," Melville's narrator slips into a nautical comparison in which he notes that the "greater the fog the more it imperils the steamer," and the ship's passengers are oblivious to the "responsibilities of the sleepless man on the bridge"; the comparison points to the
    A) differences between steamers and sailing ships.
    B) difficulties associated with authority.
    C) ever-present fog.
    D) long hours that the helmsman has to keep.
    E) odd time of the dog watch.

42. The narrator's observation that passion "is not a thing demanding a palatial stage. [. . . . And i]n the present instance the stage is a scrubbed gun deck, and one of the external provocations a man-of-war's man's spilled soup" exemplifies (a)
    A) cultural primitivism.
    B) the fourth wall.
    C) leitmotif.
    D) theater of the absurd.
    E) *theatrum mundi*.

43. Thematically, Melville's *Budd* addresses the interpretation and application of
    A) biblical analogy.
    B) impressment.
    C) law.
    D) punishment.
    E) seamanship.

44. The subtitle of Melville's novel describes the narrator's story in contrast to
    A) the admiral's report.
    B) the Dansker's moralizing.
    C) Melville's rough draft.
    D) the report found in "News from the Mediterranean."
    E) Vere's own report.

Items 45-47 refer to Marianne Moore's

What Are Years?

What is our innocence,
what is our guilt? All are
naked, none is safe. And whence
is courage: the unanswered question,
the resolute doubt,—
dumbly calling, deafly listening—that
in misfortune, even death,
encourages others
and in its defeat, stirs
the soul to be strong? He
sees deep and is glad, who
accedes to mortality
and in his imprisonment rises
upon himself as
the sea in a chasm, struggling to be
free and unable to be,
in its surrendering
finds its continuing.

So he who strongly feels,
behaves. The very bird,
grown taller as he sings, steels
his form straight up. Though he is captive,
his mighty singing
says, satisfaction is a lowly
thing, how pure a thing is joy.
This is mortality,
this is eternity.

45. Marianne Moore's contrasting of satisfaction with joy in "What Are Years?" (lines 24-25) is set up (lines 20-23) with a(n)
    A) metaphor.
    B) nonce word.
    C) oxymoron.
    D) simile.
    E) transferred epithet.

46. The theme of Moore's "What Are Years?" is
    A) accepting one's mortality.
    B) discovering one's birdlike qualities.
    C) learning to surrender.
    D) recognizing one's guilt.
    E) surrendering to the sea.

47. The last two lines of Moore's poem, "This is mortality, / This is eternity," constitute a(n)
    A) elision.
    B) hyperbole.
    C) paradox.
    D) understatement.
    E) zeugma.

Items 48-50 refer to Marianne Moore's

The Past Is the Present

The Past Is the Present

If external action is effete
and rhyme is outmoded,
I shall revert to you,
Habakkuk, as on a recent occasion I was goaded
into doing by XY, who was speaking of unrhymed
verse.
This man said—I think I repeat
his identical words:
"Hebrew poetry is
prose with a sort of heightened consciousness." Ecstasy
affords the occasion and expediency determines the
form.

48. Habakkuk (line 5) of Moore's "The Past Is the Present" is one of

A) the made-up names common in allusory poetry.
B) Moore's Jewish poetry professors.
C) the minor prophets of the Hebrew Bible.
D) the names of Moore's modernist influences.
E) the twentieth-century's famous literary critics.

49. The similarity that Moore suggests exists between Hebrew poetry and modern poetry is its lack of

A) allusion.
B) hyperbole.
C) meaning.
D) rhyme.
E) rhythm.

50. This particular poem might be recognized, especially in the declarative mood of its last sentence, as serving as Moore's own statement regarding

A) determinism in modernist poetry.
B) the importance of occasional poetry.
C) the importance of quoting authority.
D) poetry and the immediacy of the physical world.
E) the power of a good vocabulary.

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism
15 items (2 points each)

Items 51-53 refer to Steve Kowit's

The Grammar Lesson

The Grammar Lesson

A noun's a thing. A verb's the thing it does.
An adjective is what describes the noun.
In "The can of beets is filled with purple fuzz" 3

of and *with* are prepositions. *The*'s
an article, a *can*'*s* a noun,
a noun's a thing. A verb's the thing it does. 6

A can *can* roll—or not. What isn't was
or might be, *might* meaning not yet known.
"Our can of beets *is* filled with purple fuzz" 9

is present tense. While words like our and us
are pronouns—i.e. *it* is moldy, *they* are icky brown.
A noun's a thing; a verb's the thing it does. 12

Is is a helping verb. It helps because
filled isn't a full verb. *Can*'s what *our* owns
in "Our can of beets is filled with purple fuzz." 15

See? There's almost nothing to it. Just
memorize these rules . . . or write them down!
A noun's a thing, a verb's the thing it does. 18
The can of beets is filled with purple fuzz.

51. The repetition in close proximity of words that have the same roots, as found in line 14 is called

A) anaphora.
B) metathesis.
C) paradox.
D) polyptoton.
E) tautology.

52. The form of Steve Kowit's "The Grammar Lesson" is the

A) rondeau.
B) rondel.
C) roundel.
D) *terza rima*.
E) villanelle.

53. The kind of repetition in which different forms and senses of a word appear together, as found in line 7 and line 13, is called (a/n)

A) anaphora.
B) oxymoron.
C) ploce.
D) repetend.
E) tautology.

Items 54-56 refer to John Dryden's

Farewell, Ungrateful Traitor!

Farewell, ungrateful traitor!
Farewell, my perjur'd swain!
Let never injur'd woman
Believe a man again.
The pleasure of possessing
Surpasses all expressing,
But 'tis too short a blessing,
And love too long a pain.

'Tis easy to deceive us
In pity of your pain,
But when we love, you leave us
To rail at you in vain.
Before we have descried it,
There is no joy beside it,
But she that once has tried it
Will never love again.

The passion you pretended
Was only to obtain,
But once the charm is ended,
The charmer you disdain.
Your love by ours we measure
Till we have lost our treasure,
But dying is a pleasure
When living is a pain.

54. The basic metrical pattern of John Dryden's lyrical poem "Farewell, Ungrateful Traitor!" is
A) anapestic trimeter.
B) iambic pentameter.
C) iambic trimeter.
D) spondaic tetrameter.
E) trochaic trimeter.

55. The speaker in the poem is a
A) magician.
B) man.
C) swain.
D) traitor.
E) woman.

56. The use of the word *treasure* (line 22) is an instance of
A) erratum.
B) euphemism.
C) euphuism.
D) excursus.
E) exegesis.

Items 57-59 refer to Rawiri James's

Kony 2012

There once was a man named Joseph
Whose mentality some called explosive
'Cause for twenty-odd years
He has preyed on the fears
Of a nation he's now made corrosive.

In Uganda—and so someone told me,
Came this man who we now know as Kony.
He has slaughtered and killed
Sons and daughters at will
In a plan surreptitiously phony.

He's robbing a country's adolescence,
Their futures, and dreams: evanescence.
I don't understand it.
The Lord's Ten Commandments
Didn't teach this type of acquiescence.

But his reign is beginning to 'come dated,
And I'm hoping this will be fated:
To cease and desist
And force not to exist
The childhood armies he's created.

We'll shine spotlights like the 'razzi—shameless
In this celebrity world, really, who'd blame us?
In 2012
Be ready to help
Make this son of a bitch Jay-Z famous.

57. Addressing the manners and morals of a "newsworthy" personage, James's poem takes the form of the
A) limerick.
B) ode.
C) panegyric.
D) tanka.
E) villianelle.

58. Lines 13-14 of "Kony 2012" are characterized by
A) assonance rhyme.
B) feminine rhyme.
C) heteromerous rhyme.
D) internal rhyme.
E) slant rhyme.

59. Lines 11 and 12, in which *dreams* and *adolescence* are both direct objects of the verb *is robbing*, exhibit
A) ambiguity.
B) litotes.
C) metonomy.
D) syllepsis.
E) synecdoche.

Items 60-65 refer to John D. MacDonald's *Pale Gray for Guilt* (excerpted)

Tush was gone, and too many others were gone, and I sought chill comfort in an analogy of death that has been with me for years. It doesn't explain or justify. It just seems to remind me how things are.

Picture a very swift torrent, a river rushing down between rocky walls. There is a long, shallow bar of sand and gravel that runs right down the middle of the river. It is under water. You are born and you have to stand on that narrow, submerged bar, where everyone stands. The ones born before you, the ones older than you, are upriver from you. The younger ones stand braced on the bar downriver. And the whole long bar is slowly moving down that river of time, washing away at the upstream end and building up downstream.

Your time, the time of all your contemporaries, schoolmates, your loves and your adversaries, is that part of the shifting bar on which you stand. And it is crowded at first. You can see the way it thins out upstream from you. The old ones are washed away and their bodies go swiftly by, like logs in the current.

Downstream where the younger ones stand thick, you can see them flounder, lose footing, wash away. Always there is more room where you stand, but always the swift water grows deeper, and you feel the shift of the sand and the gravel under your feet as the river wears it away. Someone looking for a safer place can nudge you off balance, and you are gone. Someone who has stood beside you for a long time gives a forlorn cry and you reach to catch their hand, but the fingertips slide away and they are gone. There are the sounds in the rocky gorge, the roar of the water, the shifting, gritty sound of sand and gravel underfoot, the forlorn cries of despair as the nearby ones, and the ones upstream, are taken by the current. Some old ones who stand on a good place, well braced, understanding currents and balance, last a long time. A Churchill, fat cigar atilt, sourly amused at his own endurance and, in the end, indifferent to rivers and the rage of waters. Far downstream from you are the thin, startled cries of the ones who never got planted, never got set, never quite understood the message of the torrent.

Tush was gone, and our part of the bar was emptier [. . .].

60. The vehicle for MacDonald's analogy for life and its difficulties—a journey down a fast flowing river—serves as the passage's
A) controlling image.
B) dead metaphor.
C) epic simile.
D) lyric present.
E) moment of final suspense.

61. MacDonald's self-contradictory image of *chill comfort* (line 1) is
A) hyperbolic.
B) metonymic.
C) oxymoronic.
D) paradoxical.
E) tautological.

62. The overall style of the prose passage is marked by
A) ambiguity.
B) boustrophedon.
C) parallelism.
D) rhopalic progression.
E) sentimentalism.

63. The imagery of time washing away in the second paragraph, especially, is reinforced by
A) assonance.
B) consonance.
C) dissonance.
D) onomatopoeia.
E) sigmatism.

64. MacDonald's use of *Churchill* to suggest long-term steadfastness is an example of the
A) allonym.
B) anagram.
C) epigram.
D) eponym.
E) metonym.

65. The tone of MacDonald's prose passage is
A) contemplative.
B) disdainful.
C) insolent.
D) mournful.
E) resentful.

Tie-breaking essay prompt on the next page.

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay (required)

Note well: Contestants who do not write an essay will be disqualified even if they are not involved in any tie.

Note well: Any essay that does not demonstrate a sincere effort to discuss the assigned topic will be disqualified. The judge(s) should note carefully this criterion when breaking ties: ranking of essays for tie-breaking purposes should be based primarily on how well the topic has been addressed.

Three sheets of paper have been provided for this essay; your written response should reflect the *Handbook*'s notion that an essay is a "moderately brief discussion of a restricted topic": something more than just a few sentences.

Read Anne Sexton's "After Auschwitz," and compose an essay that addresses the persona's attitude regarding humankind.

After Auschwitz

Anger,
as black as a hook,
overtakes me.
Each day,
each Nazi
took, at 8: 00 A.M., a baby
and sautéed him for breakfast
in his frying pan.

And death looks on with a casual eye
and picks at the dirt under his fingernail.

Man is evil,
I say aloud.
Man is a flower
that should be burnt,
I say aloud.
Man
is a bird full of mud,
I say aloud.

And death looks on with a casual eye
and scratches his anus.

Man with his small pink toes,
with his miraculous fingers
is not a temple
but an outhouse,
I say aloud.
Let man never again raise his teacup.
Let man never again write a book.
Let man never again put on his shoe.
Let man never again raise his eyes,
on a soft July night.
Never. Never. Never. Never. Never.
I say those things aloud.

I beg the Lord not to hear.

published 1975

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KEY

Page numbers are those associated with the *Handbook* 11e, the Penguin 1986 edition of *Budd*, and the Folger edition of *MND*.

Part 1: Knowledge of Literary Terms and of Literary History — **30 items (1 point each)**

1.	C	233	11.	E	580	21.	B	661
2.	D	108	12.	E	588	22.	B	118
3.	B	232	13.	D	459	23.	D	398
4.	C	235; 393	14.	A	639	24.	A	46
5.	B	661	15.	E	537	25.	D	316
6.	B	146	16.	E	608	26.	B	291
7.	E	406	17.	B	80	27.	E	515
8.	A	61	18.	A	4	28.	A	50
9.	B	658	19.	E	664	29.	C	663
10.	D	415	20.	C	549	30.	A	7

Part 2: UIL Reading List — **20 items (2 points each)**

31.	C	5.1.161-63	38.	E	302	45.	A	340
32.	B	4.1.39-40	39.	D	312	46.	A	
33.	D		40.	E	353	47.	C	398
34.	A	2.1.115-17	41.	B	365	48.	C	
35.	B		42.	E	328	49.	D	
36.	A	3.1.23-24	43.	C		50.	D	
37.	B	1.1.203-04	44.	D	382			

Part 3: Ability in Literary Criticism — **15 items (2 points each)**

51.	D	428	56.	B	214	61.	C	392
52.	E	576	57.	A	314	62.	C	399
53.	C	420	58.	C	268	63.	E	513
54.	C	226	59.	D	538	64.	D	208
55.	E		60.	A	125	65.	A	

Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Anne Sexton's "After Auschwitz"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of Sexton's poem include

anaphora,
free verse,
hyperbole,
imagery,
litany,
meliorism,
metaphor,
metonymy,
personification (death),
reification (anger),
repetition,
simile,
symbol, and
tone.

The contestant is asked to discuss the persona's attitude regarding humankind. Any response to Sexton's "After Auschwitz" must acknowledge the poem's last line; the last line is essentially a rebuttal of the persona's visceral response to the banality of evil that triumphed at Auschwitz.

The personification of death, with his picking and scratching, might be recognized in terms of his patience while watching humankind prove itself capable of acts of extreme evil. This capacity is presented in the hyperbolic imagery of the Nazi breakfast and in the metaphorical declaration that "Man is a flower / that should be burnt" and the observation that "Man / is a bird full of mud."

The young writer might focus directly on the natural potential of both the flower and bird: beauty, primarily visual; symbolically, fruitful and capable of flying, soaring. That history in the guise of Auschwitz tells differently, "full of mud," is framed by the references/descriptions of death—in very unflattering personification.

The optimism explicit in the persona's "begging" God not to bring about humankind's demise—to not hear her prayer—suggests a deep regard for the potential that is humankind, reflected in her litany of humankind's accomplishments, metonymically represented: sharing, communicating, visiting, and hoping. Hands, "miraculous fingers," are capable of breaking bread, writing poems, creating comfort, and supplicating God, actions in stark contrast to the historical events, past, present, and future, represented by Auschwitz and by death's—humankind's—own dirty fingernails.